

Proposals for Process

- A. Do more formal research, such as bringing someone from CDSS (Country Dance and Song Society, national level) to describe how other communities are handling this. (Already done. Darlene is presenting results on this June 24.)
- B. Talk with other groups who've transitioned to gender-free language, to find out the process they used, and how it's worked out for them. (This discussion could be via phone, Skype, or by personal visit.)
- C. Ask Darlene to run a workshop like she did at Winter Warm-Up. The following paraphrases the person who proposed this (after confirming accuracy with Darlene):
Darlene used a highly facilitated format for small groups of people coming from diverse perspectives to sit together and approach a topic. Their goal was to make concise statements about their own values while actively listening to the others' statements. It was an excellent way to explore people's values and how they impact the dance. Darlene's format is a friendly one. We all need it. (It is poetic, too. And fun.)
Participants must sign up, as space would be limited for each group. We can schedule as many groups as there is interest for. The goal is to approach a topic, think and listen.
- D. Recruit a balanced committee of local dancers to develop a short list of Proposals for the Voting Members to decide among. Approximately 3 options for Outcomes, and possibly 3 options for Processes.
- E. Switch one Monday per month to Larks & Ravens and have the rest be gendered. Do this for a while and watch how that works out.

For example, one person proposed, IF we can afford it:

Set the 3rd Monday of each month as Gender Free and track weekly attendance for a year to evaluate. Before starting, establish benchmarks to decide whether to ultimately keep the 3rd Monday schedule, add another gender-free dance each month, or drop the gender-free dance.
- F. Create more gender-free dances rather than replacing gendered dances with gender-free. For example, add another Larks & Ravens dance each month, and watch how that works out.
- G. Have 1 - 3 gender-free test dances, with a sticky-note poll during each dance for people to choose a response. Perhaps offer 5 choices for responses, from "strongly prefer Gender-Free" to "strongly prefer Gendered language".
- H. Provide a survey to our dance community, either paper or online. Give about 5 choices for responses (as in Option G), as well as "I won't know how I feel about it until I've tried it." Perhaps also provide a space for comments. If there's sufficient interest, either make a decision or set up 2 or 3 gender-free test dances (each with a sticky-note poll) offering the same choices.
- I. Have all dancers check off a survey addressing the question: "How important is it for you to dance with Gender-Free caller terms?". Have folks who're responding print their name on the back, & maybe keep it going for multiple weeks.

See next sheet for more.

Proposals for Process, Continued

- J. Form a committee of any Voting Members who volunteer to poll the community periodically. The committee decides frequency and method of polling; also the content and wording of the questions and answers. Suggested questions:

What is your preferred role-term pair?

How do you feel about role terms at the dance? Choose from 5 responses ranging from “I will only dance to gendered terms” to “I will only dance gender-neutral”.

State the role-term pairs you like and those you dislike.

Perhaps ask about “gypsy”, # of walkthroughs, other dances to include in evening (squares, hambo), etc.

Publish raw and percentage results on our website and elsewhere as appropriate.

- K. Design, conduct, and tabulate a survey of area youth (ages 13 – 30) who are not Contra dancers to determine calling preferences for potential dancers. Possibly as follows:

“We are conducting a survey regarding dance terminology to better attract young people. With this poll we want to learn how you and your peers feel about dance instruction terminology. Our goal is to attract more young people like yourself. You'll remain completely anonymous. Would you take 90 seconds to answer a couple of questions?

We are a traditional Community Dance organization. We have been using ladies and gents to identify dance roles.

Would you find it acceptable to be addressed as a lady or a gent, or would you prefer some other gendered terms, or non-gendered terms?

(If they say they would prefer non-gendered roles:)

Which of the following would you prefer?

Ravens and larks

Lefts and rights

Jets and rubies

Leads and follows

(If they want gendered language, yet they aren't comfortable with ladies and gents, then we would ask them:)

Would you prefer to be referred to as:

Guys and gals

Men and women

Dudes and dudettes?

Do you have any suggestions?

Thank you very much for your time. Would you like a coupon for a free dance?